GROW IN CHRIST | IN-DEPTH STUDY 3

Developing a Prayer Life

Growing in Fellowship, Faith, and Dependence on God

Primary Scripture: Matthew 6:9-13 • **Memory Verse:** Ephesians 6:18

Supporting Scriptures: Luke 11:1; Romans 8:26-27; Philippians 4:6-7; Matthew 7:7-8; 1 Thessalonians 5:17

Central Teaching Truth
Prayer is an ongoing relationship with God in which believers worship, listen through His Word, ask in faith, depend on the Holy Spirit, and continue trusting Him in every season.

Lesson Objective
Learn a biblical pattern for prayer, overcome common barriers, practice stillness and worship, and grow in persistent faith while trusting God with the answer.

Introduction - Prayer Is Relationship

Prayer is more than asking God for things. It is part of our relationship with Him. Jesus' disciples said, "Lord, teach us to pray" (Luke 11:1), showing that prayer is something believers can learn and grow in. A strong prayer life begins with honesty, not impressive words.

1. Observation - What Does Scripture Say?

Read Matthew 6:5-13, Romans 8:26-27, Ephesians 6:18, and 1 Thessalonians 5:17. Answer from the passages before discussing their application.

1. What warnings and instructions does Jesus give about prayer in Matthew 6:5-8?

2. What major parts of prayer do you see in Matthew 6:9-13?

3. What does Romans 8:26 say the Holy Spirit does when we do not know what to pray?

2. Interpretation - Learning to Pray

Common barriers to prayer include fear, distraction, and not knowing what to say. Jesus teaches us to pray privately and sincerely, not to impress people. We can talk with God honestly, as we would with someone we trust deeply.

Matthew 6:9-13 gives a pattern: begin with God and His holiness, seek His will, bring daily needs, confess and forgive, and ask for spiritual protection. The pattern is not meant to turn prayer into empty repetition. It teaches us where to place our attention.

> **Simple pattern: WORSHIP - SURRENDER - ASK - CONFESS - SEEK PROTECTION.**

3. Do Not Rush Past Worship

It is easy to hurry past “Hallowed be thy name” because our needs feel urgent. Worship slows us down. We remember God’s holiness, faithfulness, mercy, wisdom, power, and love before we begin listing requests. Prayer becomes deeper when we start with the greatness of God instead of the size of our problems.

4. Learning to Be Still

Stillness can be difficult because our minds are crowded. Psalm 46:10 says, “Be still, and know that I am God.” Being still does not require an empty mind. It means intentionally giving God our attention. We can read a short passage, sit quietly, think about what it reveals about God, and ask the Holy Spirit to help us understand and apply it.

5. Praying at All Times and in Every Season

Ephesians 6:18 calls believers to pray always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit. First Thessalonians 5:17 says, “Pray without ceasing.” This does not mean keeping our eyes closed all day. It means developing a life that stays open toward God.

Scripture gives direction for many seasons: Philippians 4:6-7 for anxiety and thanksgiving; James 1:5 for wisdom; James 5:13 for suffering; Romans 8:26-27 when words fail. The more we know God’s Word, the more Scripture can shape our prayers.

6. Praying in Faith

Mark 11:24 and Matthew 21:22 teach us to pray believing. Faith does not mean that God must give us exactly what we ask on our timetable. Biblical faith trusts God’s ability, wisdom, and character. First John 5:14 reminds us to ask according to His will, and Jesus modeled surrender in Gethsemane: “Nevertheless not as I will, but as thou wilt” (Matthew 26:39).

God may answer yes, no, or wait. Waiting is not proof that He has ignored us. Through persistence He can deepen trust, form patience, and teach us dependence. Some faithful prayers may bear fruit beyond our lifetime, while other requests may be answered differently than we hoped.

> **Faith says: “I will ask because God hears. I will keep praying because I trust Him. And I will leave the result in His hands.”**

7. Application - Making Prayer a Way of Life

1. Which barrier most often interferes with my prayer life: fear, distraction, or not knowing what to say?

2. Do I usually rush past worship and go directly to my requests? What can I change?

3. What time and quiet place can I use regularly for focused prayer?

4. What Scripture can guide my prayers in the season I am in now?

A Simple Daily Prayer Practice

Practice	What to do
Worship	Begin by recognizing who God is and thanking Him.
Read	Read a short passage and let Scripture shape your thoughts.
Be still	Slow down and give God your attention.
Talk honestly	Bring fears, needs, sins, gratitude, and questions to Him.
Pray for others	Remember family, believers, leaders, and people in need.
Ask in faith	Believe God hears and trust Him with the answer.
Keep praying	Continue asking, seeking, knocking, and trusting.

8. Seven-Day Prayer Practice

Day	Scripture	Prayer focus
1	Matthew 6:9-13	Follow Jesus' prayer pattern.
2	Psalm 46:10	Practice quietness before God.
3	Philippians 4:6-7	Bring worries with thanksgiving.
4	Romans 8:26-27	Ask the Spirit to help in weakness.
5	Ephesians 6:18	Pray for others and remain spiritually alert.

Day	Scripture	Prayer focus
6	Matthew 7:7-8	Ask, seek, and knock persistently.
7	1 Thessalonians 5:17	Practice brief prayers throughout the day.

9. Group Discussion

How can we encourage someone whose prayers seem unanswered without suggesting that the person simply lacks enough faith?

Notes from our discussion:

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10. Memory Verse

Ephesians 6:18 - Read the verse in your Bible, explain it in your own words, and practice memorizing it.

Closing Prayer

Heavenly Father, teach us to pray. Help us slow down, worship You, listen through Your Word, and speak honestly with You. Strengthen our faith when answers are delayed, and help us pray in every season through the help of Your Holy Spirit. Teach us to keep asking, seeking, knocking, and trusting Your will. In Jesus' name, Amen.